

Session 3: The Importance of the Temple

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 1 describes the three-tiered cosmos as a cosmic temple. Later biblical authors will develop this theme, depicting God enthroned above the skies with the land as his footstool.
- Genesis 2 depicts the garden in Eden as a proto-temple, with humans serving as God's chosen priests.
- The tabernacle and, later, the temple serve as symbolic versions of this cosmic reality, and the journey of the high priest on the Day of Atonement into the holy of holies represents a return to Eden.

Starting Point #4: The Temple-Centered Worldview of the Biblical Story

Genesis 1:1-2:3 and 2:4-3:24 present the story of creation from two overlapping angles, both of which are rooted in a cosmic temple conception of reality.

- Genesis 1:1-2:3: God brings order out of dark chaos to create a holy cosmic order where God and humanity, Heaven and Earth, are united together in eternal Sabbath harmony.
- Genesis 2:4-3:24: Heaven and Earth are ideally bound together in Eden, where God's royal priests will mediate God's life out into the world.

The Cosmic Temple of Sabbath Harmony

The prologue and epilogue of Genesis 1 are designed as a macro-frame around the internal sequence of six days.

1:1 Summary Prologue

In the beginning, God **created** **the skies and the land** [7 words]

1:2 Exposition of Prologue in 3 Lines

Now, **the land** was wild and waste (תהו ובהו *tohu va-vohu*)

and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss (תהום *tehom*)

but the breath of *Elohim* was hovering over the face of the waters (המים *hammayim*) [7 x 2 words]

Day 1

Day 4

Genesis 1 Themes. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Day 2	Day 5
Day 3	Day 6
2:1 Summary Epilogue Thus were finished the skies and the land and all their host	
2:2-3 Exposition of Epilogue in 3 Lines 1. And God completed on the seventh day his work which he had made [7 words] 2. And he rested on the seventh day from all his work which he had made [7 words] 3. And God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it [7 words] because on it he rested from all his work which God created to make [key word of 1:1]	
<i>Genesis 1 Themes. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).</i>	

This design structure acts as an envelope around the sequence of six days, and it clearly emphasizes the sevenfold symbolism of God's actions and the culmination of the entire narrative in the seventh day.

The Meaning and Significance of Seven in Genesis 1:1-2:3

Seven is symbolic in ancient Near Eastern and Israelite culture and literature. Seven communicates a sense of fullness or completeness. "Seven" (שבע) is spelled with the same consonants as the word "complete/full" (שבע).

Seven being symbolic of completeness is likely due to the lunar calendar of moon cycles. The biblical Hebrew word for month is "moon" (חדש), which is a homonym of the Hebrew word "new." It refers to a time reckoning of 29 days in each month, so that each month consists of four seven-day cycles, making a "complete" cycle of time (see Maurice Farbridge, [Studies in Biblical and Semitic Symbolism](#), 134-137).

There are seven words (1x7) in Genesis 1:1, fourteen words (2x7) in Genesis 1:2, and twenty-one words (3x7) that describe the climactic seventh day in Genesis 2:1-3.

The concluding seventh paragraph in Genesis 2:1-3 has three lines, which have seven words each (Gen. 2:2-3a).

- And-finished / God / on-the-day / seventh / his-work / which / he did
- and-he-rested / on-the-day / seventh / from-all his-work / which / he did
- and-he-blessed / God / the-day / the-seventh / and-he-sanctified / it

There are seven paragraphs in Genesis 1:1-2:3 marked by "evening and morning."

Each of the key words in Genesis 1:1 is repeated by multiples of seven in Genesis 1:2-2:3.

- "God" = 35x (7 x 5)
- "Land" = 21x (7 x 3)
- "Skies" = 21x (7 x 3)

Key words are repeated seven times.

- “Light” and “day” on day one
- “Light” on day four
- “Living creature (חיה)” on days five through six
- “God saw that it was good”

God speaks 10 times in Genesis 1:2-2:3.

- Seven of these speeches are divine creative commands to the creation itself: “let there be ...”
- Three of these speeches are divine initiatives toward humanity: “let us make ‘adam ...,” “be fruitful and multiply,” “behold I have given to you ...”

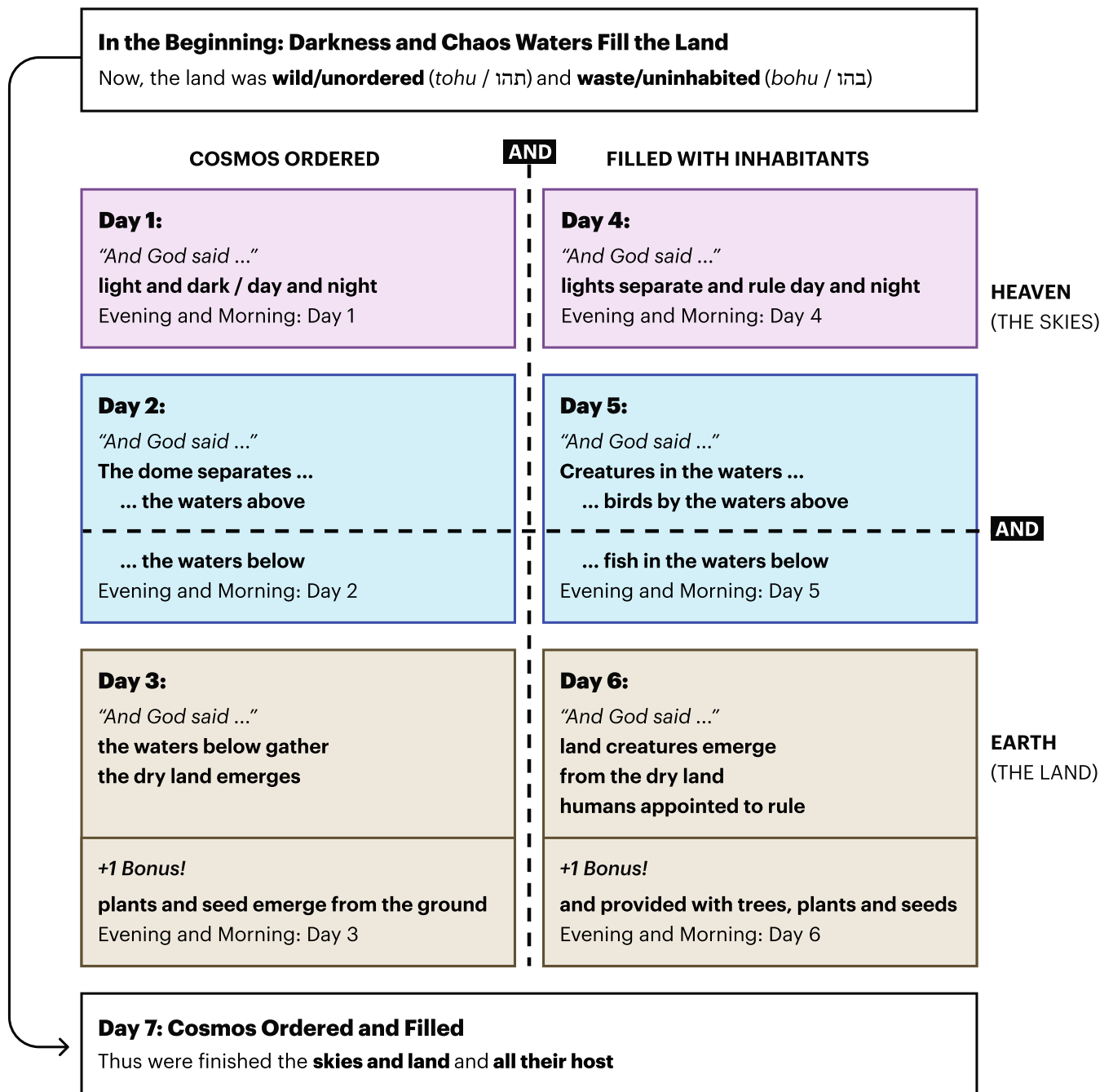
“To suppose that all these appearances of the number seven are mere coincidence is not possible. This numerical symmetry is, as it were, the golden thread that binds together all the parts of the section.”

Cassuto, Umberto (1961). [*A Commentary on the Book of Genesis: Part I, From Adam to Noah \(Genesis 1-6\)*](#). Magnes Press. 93-94.

The Cosmos of Genesis 1: Days One Through Six

Days one through six have been neatly organized as two triads that each address the “problems” with the cosmic order presented in Genesis 1:2: disorder and uninhabited darkness. Days one through three address the problem of disorder as God organizes the cosmos into distinct realms: the heavens above, the middle heaven/earth, and the land below. Days four through six then supply each of these realms with their appropriate inhabitants: the heavenly realm with lights, the middle heaven/earth with birds and fish, and the dry land with creatures and humans.

When these overlapping design structures are laid on top of each other, we get what scholar David Andrew Teeter calls “literary origami.” The six days of Genesis 1 are arranged along two “folds”—a vertical axis that forms two matching triads, and a horizontal axis that forms each triad into a mirror shape.



Origami of Genesis 1. Adapted from David Andrew Teeter by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

The “world-picture” that emerges from this conception of reality is a three-tiered cosmos of the skies, the land, and the waters under the land.

Psalm 24:1-2 NASB*

¹ The **land** is the LORD'S, and all it contains, the **world**, and those who dwell in it.

² For **he has founded it upon the seas, and established it upon the rivers.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 136:5-6 NASB*

⁵ [Give thanks] to him who made the heavens with skill, for his lovingkindness is everlasting;

⁶ to **him who spread out the land above the waters**, for his lovingkindness is everlasting;

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 20:4 NASB*

⁴ You shall not make for yourself an idol, or any likeness of what is in **the skies above** or on **the land beneath** or in **the water under the land**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Heavenly Divine Throne

The biblical cosmos consists of three tiers: the heaven, the land, and the sea, but the primary realms of the biblical drama are “the heavens and the land.”

In Genesis 1, heaven and land are two distinct yet overlapping realms. The heavenly/higher realm is transcendent, ultimate, and from there life, meaning, and order originate.

Psalm 103:19 NIV

The LORD has established **his throne in heaven**,
and his kingdom rules over all.

Isaiah 66:1-2 Instructor's Translation

⁵ This is what the LORD says:

**“The heavens are my throne,
and the land is my footstool.**

Where is the house you will build for me?

Where will my resting place be?

² Has not my hand made all these things,
and so they came into being?”

Psalm 11:4 NASB*

The LORD is in his holy temple; **Yahweh's throne is in heaven**;
his eyes behold, his eyelids test the sons of men.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Because the heavenly realm is the divine throne, it is often depicted as a “divine council” room.

Psalm 103:19-21 NIV

¹⁹ The LORD has established **his throne in heaven**,
and his kingdom rules over all.

²⁰ Praise the LORD, you his **angels**,
you mighty ones who do his bidding,
who obey his word.

²¹ Praise the LORD, all his **heavenly hosts**,
you his servants who do his will.

1 Kings 22:19 NASB

Micaiah said, "Therefore, hear the word of the LORD. I saw the LORD sitting on his throne, and all the **host of heaven** standing by him on his right and on his left."

Psalms 89:5-7 NASB*

⁵ The heavens will praise your wonders, O Yahweh;
your faithfulness also in **the assembly of the holy ones**.

⁶ For who in the skies is comparable to Yahweh?
Who among the sons of God is like Yahweh,

⁷ a God greatly feared in **the council of the holy ones**,
and awesome above all those who are around him?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

But Genesis 1 provides us with just the first cosmic-temple angle on the meaning of the cosmos. The second and most fundamental angle comes in the following narrative, Genesis 2:4-3:24 (and really, all of Genesis 1:1-11:26, but that's another story).

The Planting of Eden, the Cosmic Proto-Temple

^{4a} These are the generations of the skies and the land,
when they were created:

The Waters

^{4b} In the day when Yahweh made the land and skies,

⁵ **now**, no shrub of **the field** was yet in **the land**,
and no plant of **the field** had yet sprouted,

for the Lord God had not sent rain upon **the land**,
and there was no **human** to work the ground,

⁶ but **a stream/flow would go up** from **the land**
and it would water the whole face of the ground,

Humans in the Garden and the Tree of Life

^{a 7} **and Yahweh God formed the** **human** of dust from the ground,

- and he breathed into his nostrils the breath of life;
and the **human** became a living being.
- B a' ⁸ And Yahweh God planted a **garden in Eden**, toward the east/from of old,
a' **and he placed there the the human whom he had formed**
- b' ⁹ and Yahweh God caused to sprout from the **ground**
every tree that is desirable to sight and good for **eating**
and **the tree of life** also in the **middle of the garden**,
and **the tree of the knowledge of good and bad**.

The Waters

- ¹⁰ **Now**, **a river went out** from Eden **to water** the garden,
and from there it separated and became four heads:
- A a' ¹¹ **The name of the first** is Pishon;
b' it goes around the whole **land** of Havilah,
which has there gold
¹² and the gold of that **land** is good;
there are the bdellium and the onyx stone.
- a' ¹³ **And the name of the second** river is Gihon;
b' it goes around the whole land of Cush.
- a' ¹⁴ **And the name of the third** river is Tigris;
b' it goes east of Assyria.
- a' **And the fourth** river,
b' it is the Euphrates.

Humans in the Garden and the Tree of Death

- ¹⁵ **And Yahweh God took the human**
and he rested him in the **garden in Eden** to work (עבד • 'avad) and to keep (שמר • shamar) it.
- ¹⁶ And Yahweh God commanded the **human** saying,
- B a " **From every tree of the garden**
b **you may surely eat**
- a ¹⁷ but from **tree of the knowledge of good and bad**
b **you shall not eat from it**,
- a for in the day that **you eat from it**,
b you will surely **die**."

Genesis 2:4-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

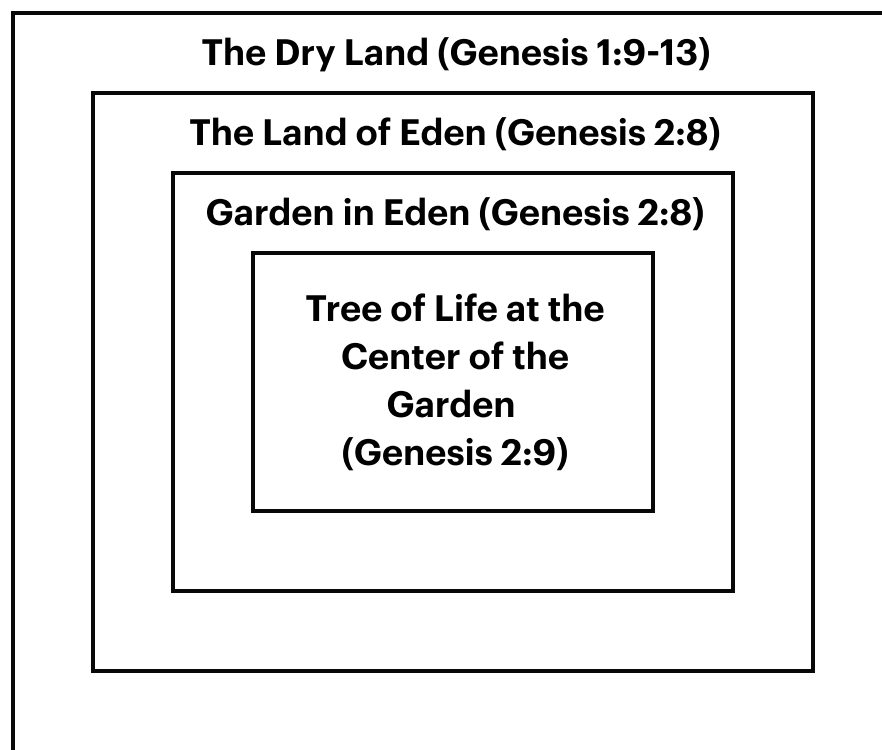
This symmetrical design invites the reader to compare the pre-garden waters (A) with the garden waters (A'). The stream/flow by itself does not create Eden in 2:4b-6, but it does create the clay and generates potential for Eden to exist. For Eden to emerge, God must direct the waters toward a purpose and then plant a garden (B), which then (B') creates an overflow of value for the nations (Israel, Egypt, Mesopotamia, Assyria).

The double placing (B and B') of humanity in the garden is intentional. The first placement in 2:7-9 and 2:10-14 is about God setting humanity in a cultivated environment that is ripe with potential. The second placement in 2:15-17 focuses on the test that the garden represents for the human.

- Genesis 2:15: “And he rested him” (וינחהו) points forward to the story of Noah (נח) who will have to bring comfort (נחם, 5:29) to the land that is cursed because of humanity’s folly in the garden by offering a sacrifice on top of the sacred mountain. This comparison invites the reader to see how God places this human atop a sacred mountain of Eden in this story as well. It also hints forward to Noah’s own failure in his garden-vineyard (Gen. 9:20-24).
- Genesis 2:16: The divine command to eat from all trees except for one sets up the plot tension of the test.
- Notice that the first introduction of the trees in (B) emphasizes the tree of life, while the introduction of the divine command (B') emphasizes the tree that could bring death.

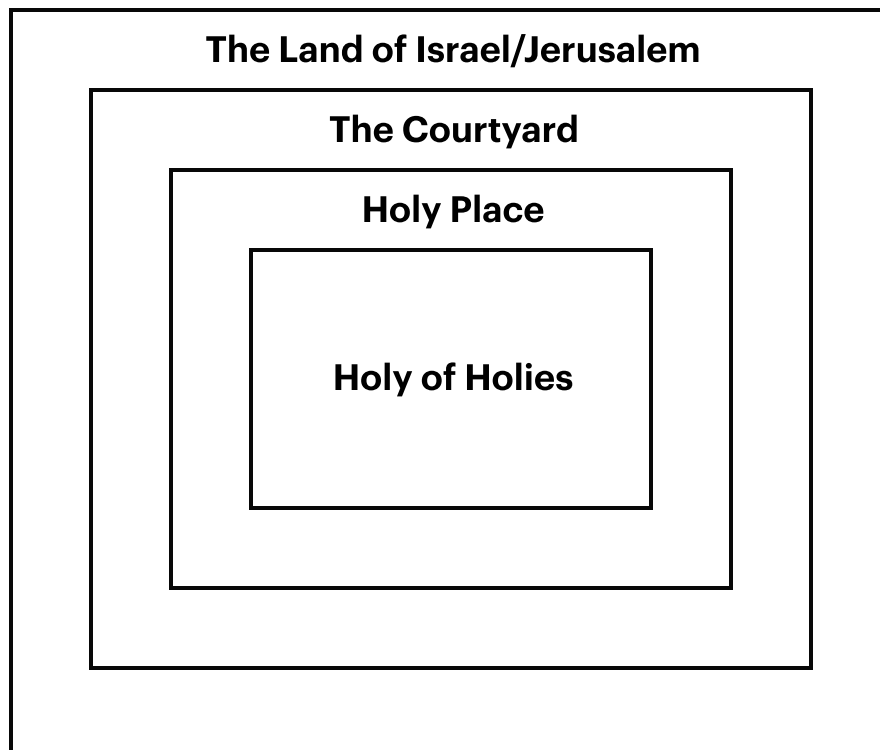
The Three-Part Geography of Eden

The geography of Eden within the dry land of Genesis 1-3 depicts a three-part topography.



Three-Part Eden Geography Diagram. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

This conception of the garden of Eden on the dry land provides a symbolic template for Israel’s tabernacle temple, especially as described in Ezekiel’s ideal/restored temple (Ezek. 40-48).



Three-Part Tabernacle Layout. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

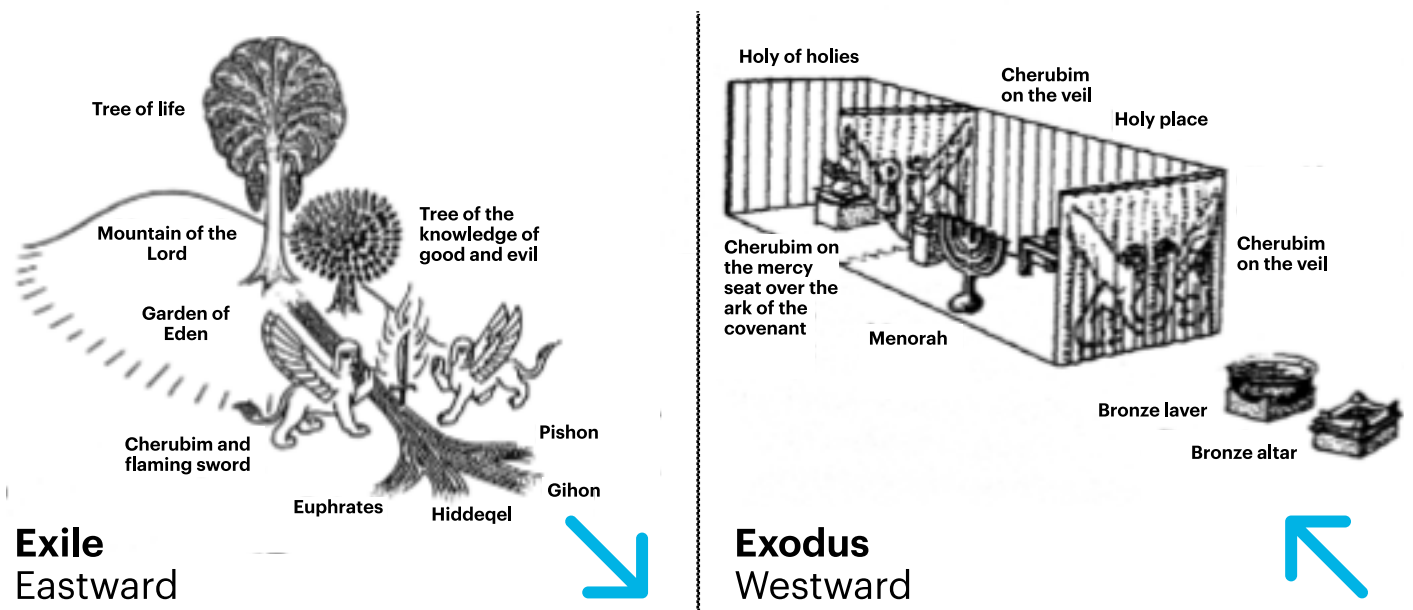


Image adapted from Morales, Michael L. (2015). *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*. IVP Academic.

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Eden as a Cosmic Mountain

Eden is depicted as a high place from which flows a river of divine life that provides life for all of the nations, and this image is foundational for the biblical storyline. Eden is "Heaven on Earth" in the form of a cosmic high place, where the life of Heaven is one with Earth.

1. Eden is a high enough place for a river to flow out to water various distant regions of the land.

Genesis 2:10 Instructor's Translation

Now, **a river went out** from Eden **to water** the garden; and from there it separated and became four head ...

2. Eden is referred to by later biblical authors as a "mountain."

Ezekiel 28:13-14 NASB

¹³You were in **Eden, the garden of God** ... ¹⁴ you were on the **holy mountain of God**.

3. The plans for the tabernacle, which is designed as a micro-Eden, are revealed to Moses on top of Mount Sinai, where he encountered Yahweh in the burning tree.

Exodus 24:16-18 NASB

¹⁶ The glory of the LORD rested on Mount Sinai, and the cloud covered it for six days; and on the seventh day he called to Moses from the midst of the cloud. ¹⁷ And to the eyes of the sons of Israel the appearance of the glory of the LORD was like a consuming fire on the mountain top. ¹⁸ Moses entered the midst of the cloud as **he went up to the mountain**; and Moses was on the mountain forty days and forty nights. ...

Exodus 25:8-9 NASB

⁸ Let them construct a sanctuary for me, that I may dwell among them. ⁹ **According to all that I am going to show you, as the pattern of the tabernacle and the pattern of all its furniture**, just so you shall construct it.

4. The Jerusalem temple, which was designed as Heaven/Eden on Earth, was built on Mount Zion, a high hill which is constantly likened to Eden.

Joel 2:1, 3 Instructor's Translation

¹ Blow the trumpet in **Zion**, sound the alarm on my holy mountain ...

³... before them [the army] the land is like the garden of Eden; behind them, a desert wasteland ...

Isaiah 51:3 NIV

The LORD will surely comfort **Zion** and will look with compassion on all her ruins; he will make her deserts **like Eden**, her wastelands **like the garden of the LORD**. Joy and gladness will be found in her, thanksgiving and the sound of singing.

Ezekiel 36:34-35 NASB

³⁴ The desolate land will be cultivated instead of being a desolation in the sight of everyone who passes by.

³⁵ They will say, "This desolate land has become **like the garden of Eden**; and the waste, desolate and ruined cities are fortified and inhabited."

"In Genesis 2-3, Eden is not explicitly described as a mountain, but this can be best understood by a careful reading of many biblical texts that symbolically identify Eden with Zion. Through the temple ritual on Mt. Zion, the cosmic images of Eden became an earthly reality. Genesis 2:10-14 mentions the four great rivers that proceed from Eden and water all the earth. One of these cosmic streams is the Gihon, which appears only elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible in reference to the main source of Jerusalem's water ... This connection between the Gihon of Eden and of Jerusalem is not the result of fuzzy or illogical mode of thought on the part of the biblical authors. This symbolic matching reflects Zion's cosmic and spiritual importance ... The image of Jerusalem's cosmic stream is no more inappropriate than similar imagery applied to Jerusalem in Psalm 48:1-3 ('Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the entire earth, Mt. Zion in the far north') or Isaiah 2:1-4 ('Mt. Zion will be raised up as the highest of all mountains on earth'). In the symbolic world of Israel's temple liturgies, ordinary space became sacred space, the meager water spring of the city became a cosmic river, and the little knoll of Jerusalem became Mt. Zion, the highest mountain on the earth, and Jerusalem, a peripheral city in the ancient world, became the center of the earth (Ezek. 38:12)."

Anderson, Gary (1988). "The Cosmic Mountain: Eden and Its Early Interpreters in Syriac Christianity." *Genesis 1-3 in the History of Exegesis: Intrigue in the Garden*. E. Mellen Press. 192-193.

5. The heavenly Jerusalem (renewed Eden on Earth) is described as a high mountain garden-city that flows with the river of life.

Psalm 46:4 NIV

There is **a river** whose streams make glad **the city of God**, the holy place where the Most High dwells.

Psalm 48:1-2 NIV

¹ Great is the LORD, and most worthy of praise, in **the city of our God, his holy mountain**. ² Beautiful in its loftiness, the joy of the whole earth, like **the heights of Zaphon is Mount Zion, the city of the Great King**.

The river of God flows out from the temple in Ezekiel 4.

Joel 3:18 NASB

And in that day the **mountains will drip with sweet wine**, and the hills will flow with milk, and all the brooks of Judah will flow with water; and **a spring will go out from the house of the LORD** to water the valley of Shittim.

Revelation 21:10 NIV

And he carried me away in the Spirit to **a mountain great and high**, and showed me **the Holy City**, Jerusalem, coming down **out of heaven from God**.

Revelation 22:1 NASB

Then he showed me **a river of the water of life**, clear as crystal, **coming from the throne of God and of the Lamb** ...

Genesis 3:22-24: Exile From Eden = From the Holy of Holies

Exile From Eden

22 And Yahweh God said,

"Look, the human has become like one of us, **knowing good and bad**,
and now so that he won't send out his hand and take also from **the tree of life** (חיים),
and eat and **live** (חי) forever ..."

23 and Yahweh God **sent him out** from the garden
to work the ground from which he was taken

24a and he **banished** the human

24b and he made to dwell at the **east of the garden of Eden**
cherubim and the flame of the whirling sword to guard way to **the tree of life** (חיים).

Genesis 3:20-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

This concluding unit represents the inversion of the Eden story's introduction.

- God creates the human and places him in the garden; the human is banished from the garden.
- God causes the tree of life and knowing good and bad to grow; humans are cut off from it.
- Before the garden, there was no human to work the ground; outside Eden the human works the ground.
- Humanity is made mortal so that by obeying God they could remain in the garden and receive the gift of eternal life; now they are cut off and sent into the land of mortality.
- Humanity is directed to "guard/keep" the garden; humanity is now guarded/kept from the garden.

The story's final line about the "cherubim" and "flame of the whirling sword" is a condensed hint that sends the reader forward to the design of the tabernacle and temple and into the prophetic visions of the divine throne room.

- Cherubim flank the ark of the covenant on the holy of holies ([Exod. 25:17-22](#)), and in the temple there are cherubim on the walls of the holy place and on the front doors into the temple ([1 Kgs. 6:29-32](#)).
- The "sword" will appear in the hand of the angel of Yahweh again when David goes to the hilltop in Jerusalem, which at the time was the threshing floor of Ornan ([1 Chron. 21:16](#)).

Coordinating the World-Pictures of Genesis 1 and 2

When we compare the cosmic geography of the first two creation narratives, we find a conceptual overlap that corresponds precisely to the spatial organization of the temple. The temple/tabernacle is a symbolic micro-cosmos, and the rituals performed within it are meant to uphold the stability and order of the world.

Tabernacle/Temple	Cosmic Geography in Genesis 1:1-2:3	Cosmic Geography in Genesis 2:4-3:24
Holy of holies	The skies	Cosmic mountain / The middle of the garden
Holy place Menorah/Palm trees Cherubim Priests	The land Fruit trees Animals Humans	The garden in Eden Fruit trees Cherubim Humans
Courtyard Bronze sea (1 Kgs. 8:64)	The waters	The land outside the garden
<i>Cosmology of Genesis 1 and 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).</i>		

“The function of these correspondences is to underscore the depiction of the sanctuary as a world, that is, an ordered, supportive, and obedient environment, and the depiction of the world as a sanctuary, that is, a place in which the reign of God is visible and unchallenged, and his holiness is palpable, unthreatened, and pervasive ... The temple was conceived as a microcosm, a miniature world. But it is equally the case that in Israel, the world, or I should say, the ideal world, was conceived as a macro-temple, the palace of God which is permeated with his presence and in which all is aligned with his will.”

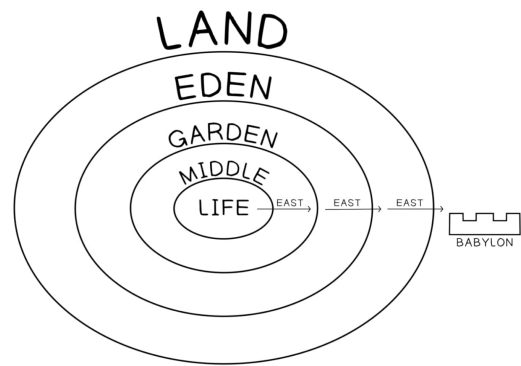
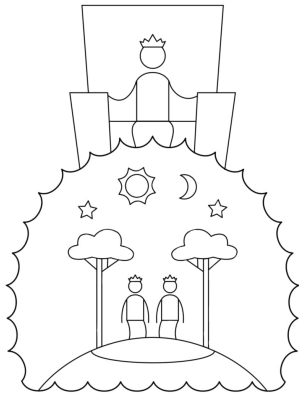
Levenson, Jon (1987). [Sinai and Zion: An Entry into the Jewish Bible](#). HarperOne. 86.

What This All Means for Understanding Ezekiel

Every part of the book of Ezekiel takes this cosmic framework and storyline for granted. The significance of Ezekiel’s visions, the God-mobile, the defiled temple and the renewed temple, and his accusations against Israel all take this point of view for granted.

- What is the meaning of Ezekiel’s “God-mobile” and temple visions in chapters 1-3, 8-11, and 40-48?
- Why does Ezekiel assume that Jerusalem is the center of the cosmos (see [Ezek. 5:5](#) and [38:12](#))?
- Why does Ezekiel think the defilement of the temple and Jerusalem requires its total destruction and re-creation?
- Why does Ezekiel think idolatry, ritual impurity, and social injustice are equal threats to the stability and order of the entire cosmos?
- Ezekiel’s view of reality is fundamentally different from our own, and we will only fully understand his writings if we sympathetically enter into his worldview.

The Three-Tiered Cosmic Temple



The Three-Tiered Cosmic Temple. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How is Ezekiel's view of the temple connected to the garden in Eden?